WHO WERE THE RESCUERS? NICHOLAS WINTON & TREVOR CHADWICK

Key Enquiry Question: How did a stockbroker and a Dorset schoolteacher team up to save 669 Czech children?

LESSON 09
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *29-year-old Nicholas Winton in Prague, early 1939, holding a young Czech child who was awaiting rescue. (Holocaust Educational Trust Archive)*

🕮 HISTORICAL READING • THE PRAGUE RESCUE OPERATION

In December 1938, a 29-year-old London stockbroker named **Nicholas Winton** cancelled his Swiss ski holiday to visit Prague. He saw thousands of terrified refugees living in freezing conditions after Nazi Germany occupied the Sudetenland.

Winton decided he could not stand by as a passive bystander. He joined forces with **Trevor Chadwick** (a schoolteacher from Swanage, Dorset) and **Doreen Warriner**. While Chadwick risked his life dealing with the Gestapo in Prague to secure exit permits, Winton worked day and night in London finding British foster families, persuading the Home Office, and raising £50 per child. Together, they saved **669 children**.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • Nicky's Scrapbook

PRIMARY SOURCE SKILLS



Source B: *Authentic scrapbook document compiled by Nicholas Winton showing passport-style photographs of Czech children (left) alongside their typed index ledger (right) marked with "placed" stamps once foster families were secured. (Yad Vashem Archive)*

1. Look closely at Source B. Notice the children's portrait photographs on the left and the typed names marked "placed" on the right. Why was it vital for Nicholas Winton to keep a photograph and index card for every single child?

2. How does this detailed filing system prove that saving 669 children required complex administrative organisation, rather than just good intentions?

Task 2: The Three-Link Rescue Chain • Who Made It Possible?

HISTORICAL CAUSATION

LINK 1 • PRAGUE

Trevor Chadwick & Doreen Warriner

Interviewed desperate parents in Prague hotel, secured official exit permits from the Gestapo, and escorted children to trains.

What dangers did Chadwick face?

LINK 2 • THE CONTINENT

The 8 Special Trains

Steam trains carried the children across Germany and the Netherlands to the Hook of Holland ferry to Harwich, Britain.

Why was the journey nerve-wracking?

LINK 3 • LONDON

Nicholas Winton & Foster Families

Found British sponsors willing to pay the £50 government bond, met trains at Liverpool Street, and placed children in safe homes.

Why was Winton's work vital?

Task 3: The 50-Year Secret • The Scrapbook in the Attic

HISTORICAL EMPATHY & CHARACTER

The Book That Stood Silent for Half a Century

For 50 years after the war, Nicholas Winton never told a single person about the 669 children he saved—not even his own wife, Grete. In 1988, Grete was tidying their attic when she discovered a dusty leather scrapbook containing lists of names, photographs, and letters from grateful parents. When asked why he kept silent for so long, Winton simply replied that the war was over and there was no reason to boast about doing what anyone should have done.

What does Winton's 50-year silence reveal about his true motivations and character?

Task 4: Thinking Heads • Two Rescuers at Work

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 Trevor Chadwick (Prague Platform)

What thoughts and fears might Trevor Chadwick have on the platform?

2 British Foster Mother (Liverpool St)

What thoughts and hopes might a British foster parent have at the station?

Task 5: Master Synthesis • What Makes an Upstander?

MORAL & HISTORICAL REASONING

Big Question: What is the vital difference between a bystander and an upstander, and what can we learn from the rescuers today?